



How can technology help solve 7 basic problems that are holding India back?

Team Digit
editor@thinkdigit.com

We've come a long way as a country in the 63 years since we gained independence. We've become

one of the world's most influential economies, we've launched our own satellites, sent probes to the moon, become nuclear capable, and done it against all odds, despite enormous problems of over-population, corruption, hunger and illiteracy.

Technology is one specific area where we've grown like crazy, and it plays a rather large part towards our GDP. Based on numbers released by a Department of Information Technology (DIT) report, IT in India has gone from just over \$10 billion in 2001-2002 to almost \$60 billion in 2008-2009. A rough estimate puts that at just a little over 5 per cent of our GDP. A NASSCOM report suggests that India will earn \$63 billion in 2010 from IT software and services. But enough with the numbers...

What doesn't change is the fact that these huge amounts of money are being earned by a relatively small number of

people, and thus do not really benefit the masses of our country. What also doesn't change is the sad fact that there's no Indian-made iPhone, or any Indian company that can hold a candle to Microsoft, Google, Apple, and the likes, or any real made-in-India IT success story. Why?

Indian farmers still commit suicide on a frighteningly regular basis. Why?

Most of us curse the pothole-laden roads we travel on, and we've been doing

so for years, but some things never change. Why?

Solutions?

We're all looking for answers, and we all have friends who will sit around and wax eloquent about how this or that is to blame, whilst others will blame governments, the population, corruption – or basically as many reasons as problems. But where are the solutions?

Whatever the problems, we at Digit feel that the only answers lie in technology. We're way beyond the point where we can hope for things to "work themselves out", and the only way we're ever going to see a visible change is if we start building the technology innovations we need. And it has to be "us" who builds them. By us, we mean Indians, living in India, working on Indian problems.

The reason we're stressing on the Indian-ness of the solution providers, is that we don't think too many foreign companies care about our problems. While the same companies will most certainly try and sell you their latest gadgets, they're certainly not bothered by our farmers committing suicide. Just as we aren't really bothered by the problems in other countries, unless they start affecting our incomes, or interfering with our lives.

What needs fixing

Team Digit sat down and thought long and hard about what areas of our lives most need technology innovations, and where technology can be most effective. The following pages of this article will list each of the seven problem areas and our thoughts on how technology can fix them.

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What we want from you is to put on that thinking cap, and come up with solutions that build on what we've suggested, or even something we haven't touched upon at all, and suggest ways in which technology can do away with those problems. We're calling this little project of ours "Tech Kranti", because we believe that India has enough innovative

thinkers and implementors to get the job done. All people really need is a stiff kick in the pants, and a carrot to chase to get movements like this going. In this case, the reality of your daily problems ought to be a stiff enough pant-kicker, and understanding that the first people to implement these ideas are likely to not only help their country, but also get filthy rich in the process, ought to be enough of a carrot to make enough gaajar-ka-halwa to feed our poor.

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